

Time After Time:

How Compulsive Denial Turns to Downfall in Oscar Wilde's *A Picture of Dorian Gray*

Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* sends a clear message to its readers: denial interferes with happiness. The novel was published as a novella in 1890 and revised in 1891. Wilde argues that the notion of the time that happiness comes from wealth, status, and possessions is wrong, and only creates an artificial sense of being happy. Throughout his life, Dorian Gray uses denial as a drug and blots out the memories of people he's hurt in order to escape his harsh reality. Poisoned by the influence of fellow aristocrat Lord Henry, Dorian not only fears facing his problems, but avoids doing so at all costs. He uses denial to separate himself from guilt and pain until it becomes too much to handle, and Dorian, as well as the people around him, are adversely affected. Over the course of the novel, Dorian uses possessions and drugs to distract himself from reality. These hedonistic tendencies ultimately bring misfortune and suffering into his life. Wilde's narrative suggests that denying guilt for a superficial version of happiness only multiplies it and that swallowing the truth, however gut-wrenching it may be, is imperative to living a successful and fulfilling life.

At the beginning of the novel, Dorian's friend Basil paints a portrait of him. As the story progresses and Dorian does more morally reprehensible things, the painting's image of him ages and becomes more ugly, contrasting with Dorian's forever-young and beautiful appearance. After the first change, a faint sneer replacing his smile, Dorian refuses to look at the painting a second time, and when he eventually does, he covers the portrait with a sheet: a physical act of denial. "He [Dorian] almost dreaded the valet leaving the room. He knew that when he was alone he would have to examine the portrait. He was afraid of certainty" (Wilde 95). This inner monologue from *Dorian Gray* clearly illustrates how he was scared to see the portrait because it

would confirm his suspicions. Wilde portrays this as more of an unconscious fear of certainty—both of the painting really changing, and of his own immorality—than a deliberate choice to obliterate his past. The painting shows a cruel smile, which, unbeknownst to Dorian, is because of his treatment of Sybil Vane—an actress he rejected despite their plans for a life together. Sybil’s death was partly caused by Dorian’s coldheartedness. His denial of his own actions is a precursor to all of the pain he later causes and experiences in his attempts to masquerade as happy.

As the book progresses, Dorian commits many horrendous acts and excuses them with twisted logic—which he acquired from Lord Henry’s influence—just so he does not have to feel guilt and remorse. He moves from fear of certainty to fear of consequence. This is when Dorian murders Basil. Beyond that, he uses his former friend Alan Campbell to cover up the murder, so he will not have to face the unwanted consequences of his actions.

“It was long after seven when Campbell came back into the library. He was pale, but absolutely calm. ‘I have done what you asked me to do,’ he muttered. ‘And now, good-bye. Let us never see each other again.’ ‘You have saved me from ruin, Alan. I cannot forget that,’ said Dorian simply. As soon as Campbell had left, he went upstairs.

There was a horrible smell of nitric acid in the room. But the thing that had been sitting at the table was gone” (Wilde 173).

This is a prime example of Dorian’s hedonism as it pertains to denial. Dorian does not care about how his choices affect other people; he simply does not want to acknowledge the hurt he causes—that would mean accepting the burden of guilt. Dorian blackmails Campbell into traumatizing himself by covering up the murder and is totally numb to Campbell’s pain. He only talks about what Alan did to help him and ignores the rest. Dorian refuses to feel guilt or

empathy, so he does not register any harm he causes. In the quote, Dorian refers to Basil's dead body as "the thing that had been sitting at the table." This choice of words illustrates that Dorian does not even see Basil as a person. All Gray sees is a "thing" negatively affecting him, and in his mind, that justifies him doing whatever it takes to get rid of it. Dorian's way of being happy is not to fill his life with the things he loves and the people he cherishes, but to remove all of the things that hurt or restrain him in any way. He strives for happiness but achieves apathy, a sort of limbo in which nothing can hurt him, so he can never be unhappy. Dorian kills Basil and uses Campbell as a tool, just so he can live without facing repercussions for his actions.

During the final few chapters of the novel, Wilde depicts Dorian becoming addicted to opium, and using it as a coping mechanism. Wilde pushes Dorian's tendency to ignore pain to an extreme. "To cure the soul by means of the senses, and the senses by means of the soul.' Yes, that was the secret. He had often tried it, and he'd try it again now. There were opium dens where one could buy oblivion, dens of horror where the memory of old sins could be destroyed by the madness of sins that were new" (Wilde 183). Wilde specifically mentions curing the soul in this quote. The portrait, the personification of all the torment Dorian caused, is his soul and conscience. Dorian finds it repulsive in many instances in the book, so "curing the soul" is really just burying it. Dorian uses opium to "cure" the tangible consequences of his actions. By blotting out the pain and guilt he should be feeling, Dorian can look at the actions as an unfortunate circumstance, or an artistic and tragic experience, as he did with Sybil Vane's death. However, as Dorian develops, he is not able to block out remorse as easily, so he turns to opium. Dorian believes he can "destroy old sins," but all he does is submerge them. He tries to achieve happiness by removing sadness, but it ends in apathy. His happiness is false, powered artificially by opium. At this point, Dorian has no close friends and no support system. He does not have

anyone who makes him happy, so he fills the void with material possessions and opium. He tries to ignore the guilt that ravages him, but it compounds inside him. All of the sufferings he caused are rooted inside him, and when this dam of emotions finally bursts, Dorian's greatest fear is brought to fruition. He becomes the wretched depiction of his soul in Basil's portrait: twisted, unrecognizable, and dead.

Throughout *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, Oscar Wilde depicts how compulsive denial of harsh realities only makes those realities harsher, and ruins any fulfillment one could have in their life. This idea is illustrated through a once innocent Dorian gradually starting to deny the hard truths of life and rejecting certainty until he no longer is able to. The theme Wilde depicts in the novel is universal: everyone wants to shut out pain at some point, but this book teaches one to face reality and fight through it.